~~TOP SECRET~~

MEETING: Chairman Mao Tse-tung and Secretary Kissinger, Oct 21, 1975, 6:22 pm
Place

People attending the meeting: (from left to right)

Foreign Minister Chiao Kuan-hua
Vice Premier Teng Hsiao-ping
Nancy Tang Wang-sheng (Nancy Tang)
Chairman Mao
Secretary Kissinger
George Bush
Winston Lord
Amb Huang Chen
1 empty chair

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Behind Nancy Tang: Madame Chang Han-chih, wife of Foreign Minister

Closer to Mao: Wang Hai-jing, Vice Foreign Minister

In addition, there was a member of Chairman Mao's staff who helped him hold the tablet for writing throughout the meeting. She was right behind the Chairman.

N.B. Prior to the actual meeting, there was a hand-shaking session where the Americans listed above, plus Habib, Gleysteen, Peter Rodman, Sonnenfeldt, and Anne Boddicker, a lady notetaker from the State Department, participated.

THE CONVERSATION

Mao: I am going to heaven soon. I have already received an invitation from God. (

(N.B. I am struck that Mao cannot speak at this point. He laboriously writes characters. His interpreters, principally Nancy Tang, Wang Hai-jing, Madame Chang, desperately try to grasp what he is saying. It's almost like playing "The Game" where you keep throwing out words to see if the actor can simply answer "yes" when you hit the right word.)

Kissinger: Don't accept it soon.

Mao: I accept the orders of the doctor.

(N.B. At this point he is writing out characters on his hand trying to make himself understood.)

Kissinger: I attach significance to our relationship.

Mao: You are this, we are that. You have the atomic bomb and we don't

(N.B. At this point he is holding his fingers, one like a large finger or full hand, and then holding up just the little finger at the point he is saying you are this, we are that.)

Kissinger: But China says military strength is not the only thing.

Mao: As Teng said (at this point, he points to Teng Hsiao-ping), "Millet and rifles".

Kissinger: And we have common opponents.

Mao: Yes.

(N.B. He writes this out in English. Nancy Tang holds it up to show the "y e s" and gives the piece of paper to Secretary Kissinger.) (I am struck that the girls are looking absolutely adoringly at him. The men greeted him with a special reverence, feet together, knees together, bowing knees slightly and grasping of hand in a respectful, almost worshipful way. It is the aura around the Chairman that's most impressive.)

Mao: Have you quarreled?

(N.B. Here he is referring and points to both Kissinger and Teng.

Kissinger: Only about means to common objectives.

Mao: Yesterday, during your quarrels with the Vice Premier you said the US asks nothing from China, and China asks nothing from the United States. This is partially right, this is partially wrong.

(N.B. He writes more characters at this point.)

Mao: The small problem is Taiwan. The big issue is the world. If neither side had anything to ask from the other, why would you be coming to Peking?

(N.B. He writes some more here. He'd obviously been briefed on the Teng-Kissinger talks.)

Mao: If neither side wants anything from the other, why would you come to Peking? Why would we be receiving your President?

Kissinger: Because you have the clearest perception of any country that we deal with.

(N.B. This is not a complete Kissinger statement.)

Mao: That's not reliable. (Interpreter than changed to "Those words are not reliable".)

(N.B. It is now 6:45. The conversation began just before 6:30.)

Mao: Those words not reliable because in your priorities, first there is the USSR, Europe, then Japan, then fourth is China.

(N.B. Mao gesturing with fingers here.)

Kissinger: That is not correct.

Mao: It is in my view.

Kissinger: It is not correct.

Mao: (Putting one finger to another, one finger on one hand to another finger on another had) So then we quarrel.

Kissinger: The USSR is a danger to us but does not have high priority.

Mao: That's not correct. It's a super power, and there only 2 super powers in the world. We are backwards. America, USSR, Europe, Japan, China - we come last.

Kissinger: We almost never disagree but he's not correct on this point only because it's a matter of our priority (incomplete).

Mao: We say what you are doing is leaping to Moscow by way of our shoulders, and these shoulders are now useless. We are the small finger (here he holds out his hand).

Kissinger: We have nothing to gain in Moscow.

Mao: But you can gain Taiwan in China. (This was then changed by the interpreter to: "But you now have Taiwan in China.")

Kissinger: But we'll settle that between us.

Mao: In a hundred years.

Kissinger: That's what/ the Chairman [redacted] said last time. It won't take 100 years

Mao: It is better for Taiwan to be on your hands and if you were to send it back to me I'd not want it. It is not wantable. There are a huge bunch of counter-revolutionaries there. One-hundred years hence we will want it, and we are going to fight for it.

(N.B. Here Mao's gutteral sounds become much more animated.)

Kissinger: In a hundred years?

Mao: It is hard to say. 5 years, 10 years, 20 years, 100 years. It is hard to say. When I go to heaven to see God I will tell him it is better to have Taiwan under the care of the US now.

Kissinger: He'll be astonished to hear that from the Chairman.

Mao: No. Because God blesses you, not us. God does not like us, because I am a militant war lord, also a Communist. That's why He doesn't like me. He likes you three here (he points to we three). That's true.

Kissinger: I've never had the pleasure of meeting Him.

Mao: I'm sure. I'm 82 years old now. How old are you?

Kissinger: 51.

Mao: Ask Teng how old he is.

Teng: 71.

(N.B. Teng looks very pleased to be asked this question by the Chairman.)

Mao: After we are all dead, myself, him (pointing to Teng), Chou en-lai, and Yeh Jen-ying, you will still be alive. We old ones are not going to make it out.

Kissinger: If I might say one thing about what the Chairman said. Because the Soviet Union is a super power we must deal with it tactically But in terms of strategy we are trying to contain Soviet expansion. This is why in strategy it is important to us. But we don't want to use China to jump to Moscow. That would be suicidal.

Mao: You've already jumped there, but you no longer need our shoulders

Kissinger: We haven't jumped there. It's a tactical phase which the President will affirm when he comes to China.

Mao: Please convey my regards to the President. We [redacted] welcome his visit. (At this point, he points to his mouth to extend welcome.) Do you have any way to assist me to speak clearly?

Kissinger: You make yourself understood very well.

Mao: This part (here he points to his head) works well. I can eat and sleep. These parts (here he taps his legs and I notice a bandaid on his left [redacted] leg above the ankle bone towards the middle of the shin,but on the left side), these parts not work well, they are not firm when I walk. I also have some trouble with my lungs. In one word, I am not well -- majorly unwell.

Kissinger: It's always a great joy to see the Chairman.

Mao: (writing again) I am a showcase exhibit to visitors.

Kissinger: I have read over our conversation of two years ago. It was a profound exposition of international affairs and we take it very seriously.

Mao: But still some things that we must wait to observe. (He writes again.)[redacted]

(At this point he seems to be coming alive much more, much more animated, responding much more quickly, head moving promptly, obviously sharper than at the beginning of the conversation. The conversation seems to be stimulating him.)

Mao: But still there are some things that we must wait to observe. Some of the assessments I made still have to be proved by observing the situation.

Kissinger: Basically you have been proved correct. Basically we agree with it. We've been through a difficult period in the United States due to the resignation of President Nixon, requiring more maneuvering than we would like.

Mao: I think that can be done. Maneuvering is allowable.

Kissinger: Essential. But we are putting that behind us.

Mao: Europe is too soft now.

Kissinger: We agree with the Chairman.

Mao: They are afraid of the Soviet Union.

Kissinger: Afraid of the Soviet Union and of their domestic situation.

Mao: Japan itself is seeking hegemony.

Kissinger: Japan is not ready to seek hegemony. That will require one more change of leadership. Potentially, it has potential to seek hegemony.

Mao: Yes.

Kissinger: Next generation of leaders, including my student Nakasony - that generation more ready to use the power of Japan.

(N.B. It is now 7:07 p.m.)

Mao: Europe is too scattered, too loose.

Kissinger: We prefer Europe to be more unified and stronger.

Mao: That is also our preference, but it is too loose and spread out and difficult to achieve unity.

Kissinger: There are not many strong leaders.

Mao: Yes.

Kissinger: Schmidt, who comes here next week, is the strongest of the leaders in Europe.

Mao: France is afraid of Germany.

(N.B. Here he holds up his left fist.)

Mao: They are afraid of the reunification of West Germany and East Germany which result in a fist.

Kissinger: France prefers to keep Germany divided.

Mao: That's not good.

Kissinger: But they may unite on a nationalistic basis.

Mao: We are in favor of reunification.

Kissinger: It depends on whom.

Mao: West Germany has a population of 50 million while East Germany has a population of 18 million.

Kissinger: West Germany is the strongest side materially.

Mao: But unification of Germany now would not be dangerous.

Kissinger: We favor it. But right now unification would be prevented militarily by the Soviet Union. We in the US support reunification.

Mao: We agree on that.

Kissinger: We are not afraid of unifying Germany but the Soviet power must be weakened before it happens.

Mao: (long wait, writes characters) Without a fight the Soviet Union cannot be weakened.

Kissinger: But it is important for us to pick the right moment for this, and during the period of Watergate we were in no position to do that. That's why we had to maneuver.

Mao: It seems not necessary to conduct the Watergate affair in that manner.

Kissinger: It was inexcusable to conduct it in that manner. A minor event wasplayed into a national tragedy. Richard Nixon was a good President and I am still in frequent contact with him. (Not complete [redacted] Kissinger comment here.)

Mao: Please convey my regards to President Nixon.

Kissinger: I'll call him when I return.

Mao: Please first send my regards to President Ford, second please send my regards to President Nixon. You are too busy.

Kissinger: You think I travel too much?

Mao: I was saying you are too busy and it seems it won't do if you're not busy. (Translator changed this, added: "Can't keep from being so busy.")

Mao: When the wind and the rain are coming the swallows are busy.

Kissinger: It will take me several days to understand the significance of that.

Mao: The world is not tranquil. In a storm, the wind and the rain are coming. At the approach of the wind and the rain the swallows are busy.

Kissinger: I hope we have a little more effect on the storm than the swallows do on the wind and the rain.

Mao: It is possible to postpone the arrival of the wind and the rain but impossible to keep it from coming.

Kissinger: (incomplete) We agree the wind and the rain may well be coming, but we want to put ourselves in the best position, not to avoid it, but to overcome it.

Mao: Dunkirk!

Kissinger: Not for us.

Mao: You can say that is not the case for you how.

Kissinger: Not in the future.

Mao: That is not reliable. A military correspondent for the New York Times put out a book in August. Do you think 300,000 troops [redacted] the US has in Europe will be able to resist Soviet attack?

Kissinger: The weakness is not our troops. With nuclear weapons we can resist the attack.

Mao: That correspondent didn't believe the US would use its nuclear weapons.

Kissinger: The New York Times has had a vested interest in US defeat all during the last 10 years. There are _____ nuclear weapons in Europe and they are not there to be captured (not complete).

Mao: But there is a considerable [redacted]portion of American who don't believe you'd use them. They don't believe America is willing to die for Europe.

Kissinger: It is a difficult period. Many defeatist elements in our country (not complete). In every crisis in the last 5 years where the US confronted the USSR they have always backed down. I can assure you we'd use nuclear weapons. President Ford will assure you of that.

(N.B. I note that Teng's deafness causes Chiao Kuan-hua to interpret for him on almost everything that is said. It is now 7:30. The conversation has been going for an hour and ten minutes and Mao is more animated and more sharp than at the beginning. He is doing amazingly well.)

Mao: You believe in nuclear weapons. You don't have confidence in your own army.

Kissinger: Not as large an army as the Soviets. No European country would build a large army. Therefore we must build a strategy suited to that reality.

Mao: The Dunkirk strategy is not undesirable either.

Kissinger: There will be no Dunkirk strategy, neither in West or East. If there is attack, after we mobilize we are certain to win a war against the Soviets.

Mao: We'd adopt a Dunkirk strategy. We'd allow them to occupy Peking, Tientsin, Wuhan and Shanghai, and in that way we would become victorious and every enemy defeated. Both world wars conducted in that way. Victory was attained only later.

Kissinger: My belief about a Soviet attack is that the US is involved. My belief is the US would never withdraw from Europe without a war.

Mao: Now there are two possibilities. One is your possibility, the other is that of the New York Times. That is also reflected in Senator Goldwater's speech of June 3rd in the New York Times.

Kissinger: What'd he say?

Mao: We'll send you a copy. It was a foreign policy debate. (Nancy Tang adds: It was in a foreign policy debate.)

Kissinger: What was his point?

Mao: Disbelief in Europe.

Kissinger: Much said before election for domestic consumption. The New York Times has a certain position. For 30 years they've an unparalleled record for being wrong.

Mao: It is said the New York Times is controlled by a Jewish family, also the Washington Post.

Kissinger: It is no longer true.

(N.B. Kissinger asked me about Kay Graham and I told him that she was Eugene Meyer's daughter, and yes she is Jewish.) Kissinger conveys this to Mao.)

Mao: Yes, the proprietress is a Jew.

(N.B. Mao writing alot now.)(He turns and points to George Bush:)

Mao: This Ambassador is in a plight. Why don't you come look me up?

G.B.: I would be honored, but I'm afraid you are very busy.

Mao: I'm not busy. I don't look after the internal affairs. I only read international news.

Kissinger: You read more than I do.

Mao: You don't have time.

(N.B. Mao jokes with Winston Lord, and then says, pointing to both Lord and Kissinger:)

Mao: You've been promoted, and he hasn't (pointing at GB).

Kissinger: He will be in 1980.

(N.B. Kissinger makes some reference to my running for President in 1980.)

Mao: You don't know my temperament. I like people to curse me. You must slam on the chair and say "Mao Tse-tung is an old bureaucrat". In such a case I'll meet you. If you don't curse me, I won't meet you. I'll just sleep peacefully.

Kissinger: You're not a bureaucrat.

Mao: I'll only be happy when all the foreigners slam on the table and curse me. But I am a bureaucrat, and moreover I am also a warlord. This is the title I was given by the Soviet Union. The title bureaucrat was also given by the Soviet Union.

Kissinger: I haven't seen any Soviet visitors here lately.

Mao: They are cursing me every day, every comment, every day.

Kissinger: We don't share Soviet assessment of China.

Mao: Therefore I've accepted these two titles: war lord and bureaucart. No honor could be greater; and you have said, "You're a warmonger and a dresser". (agressor)

Kissinger: I?

Mao: US and the UN has said that. The UN passed a resolution saying we committed agression against Korea.

Kissinger: 25 years ago.

Mao: So it's not directly linked to you?

Kissinger: It was long ago, and our perception has changed.

Mao: But the resolution hasn't been cancelled and so I am using this hat "agressor" (here he points to his head). It's a great honor, good, very good.

Kissinger: Then we shouldn't change the resolution?

Mao: Never. Don't do it. We've never put forward that request. We prefer to wear this cap of honor. Chiang Kai-shek is saying that we have committed aggression against China. We have no way to deny that. We don't deny that. We have indeed created aggression against China and also in Korea. So please assist me in making this statement public, perhaps in one of your briefings, that is, that the Soviet Union confers the title of warlord and bureaucrat and the US calls me an aggressor.

Kissinger: I'd better let you make that public.

Mao: I've already said this to many foreigners, including Europeans. Don't you have freedom of speech?

Kissinger: Absolutely.

Mao: I also have free speech, and canons I have fired exceed theirs (pointing to the Foreign Minister and the Vice Premier).

Kissinger: I've noticed.

Mao: Please send my regards to your Secretary of Defense. I am dissatisfied that he went to Japan without coming to Peking. WE want to invite him here for the Soviets to see. But you are too miserly. The US is so rich, but on this point you are too miserly.

Kissinger: We can discuss it.

Mao: Bring him along. He can bring both a civilian and a military man

Kissinger: Me as a civilian and Schlesinger as a military man?

Mao: Yes, but up to your side who to send. (He makes some reference to internal matter.)

Kissinger: He won't come with the President.

Mao: I'd like to invite him to pay a visit to the Northeast, including Mongolia and Singkiang. Perhaps he would not go.

(Pointing to GB) Mao says: He has been to the Northeast. Perhaps you'd not have the courage to go.

Kissinger: Yes I would like that.

Mao: As for military aspect, we should not discuss that now. Such matters should wait until war breaks out before we consider them.

Kissinger: (I missed a quote here, but made some reference about that we would be prepared.)

The meeting broke up somewhat abruptly. I noticed no signal.

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